

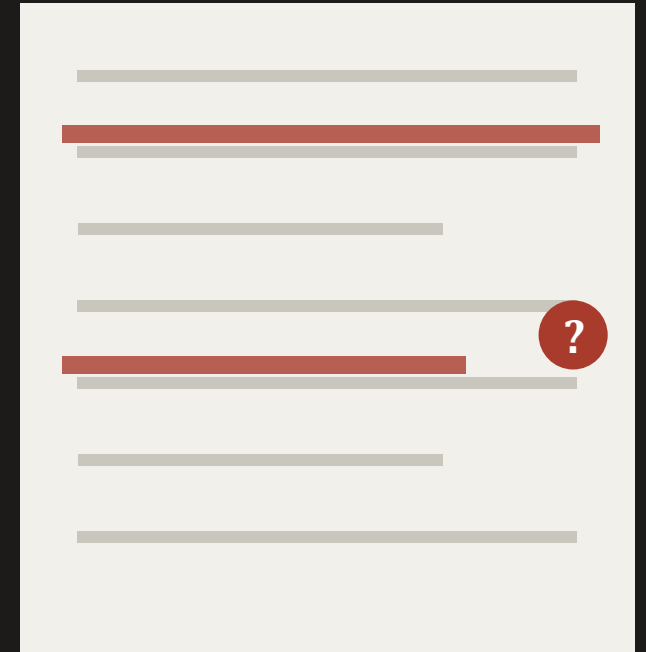
AI IN SPECULATIVE MEDIA AND LITERATURES · CRITIQUE WORKSHOP

Essay Workshop

Ovid, Sekien, and the Motif of Transformation

An undergraduate honors thesis — 28 pages, comparative, on two texts this course has already taught

Session: Reconstruct, credit, critique, revise.



How to take an argument apart

Steelman before you strike

State the argument in a form its author would accept, and ideally in a form slightly stronger than they managed.

Attack the load-bearing wall

Typos and a misspelled name are worth thirty seconds at the end. The question that matters is: which single claim, if it failed, would bring the rest down? Find that, and test it first.

Every objection owes a repair

Naming a problem is easy and half a contribution. The other half is saying what the essay should have done instead.

And one more, particular to today

This is an honors thesis by an undergraduate who read in two traditions, one of them in translation with help.

What the essay sets out to do

A comparison of Ovid's *Metamorphoses* with Toriyama Sekien's *Gazu Hyakki Tsurezure Bukuro* (1784), arguing that the two use the motif of transformation in mirror-image ways: Ovid turns people into objects and takes their power away; Sekien turns objects into people and gives them power.

The Ovid half

Two tales, Daphne and Narcissus. Physical transformation happens to the persecuted; mental transformation happens to the persecutors, who fall in love. Love is read as a figure for poetic inspiration. The whole is read as a coded account of Ovid's own banishment.

The Sekien half

Two plates, Ungai-kyō and Princess Suzuhiko. Yokai in the book fall into two kinds — objects transformed by reaching a hundred years, and objects made famous by a legendary owner. Read as self-projection and self-exploration respectively.

The comparison

Ovid was disempowered by exile, so his agents are disempowered. Sekien was empowered by self-discovery, so his agents are empowered. The direction of transformation tracks the state of the author.

Observation

It compares exactly the two texts we taught in Units 1 and 4, it was written by a third year undergraduate without a graduate seminar behind it, and its central problems are somewhat common in college essays.

Three things this essay does correctly

The comparison is real, and nobody else has made it

1

Putting a first-century Latin poem next to an eighteenth-century Japanese print book is interesting. Both are compendia of transformations, both are organised by motif rather than plot, and the observation that they run in opposite directions — person to object, object to person — is a structural insight that does not appear in the scholarship on either.

The Narcissus reading is coherent

2

The essay argues that Narcissus's transformation is not the flower but the whole scene — flower plus pool, so that the bloom can go on seeing its reflection. That is a real close reading, it is correct, and it is the kind of observation that only comes from looking at the text rather than at the criticism.

The Sekien evidence is properly evidentiary

3

Two moves stand out. First: annotation increases across the four books, which is offered as evidence that the later yokai were less familiar and therefore likelier to be invented. Second: in the Ungaikyo plate the spirit is drawn in dots while the rail and curtains are drawn in solid line — the technique marks ontological status. Both are checkable claims about the object itself.

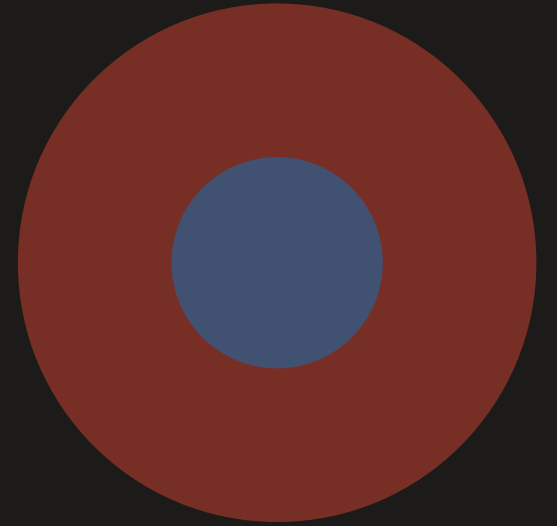
However, the third one is the methodological standard the rest of the essay does not meet.

THE CRITIQUE

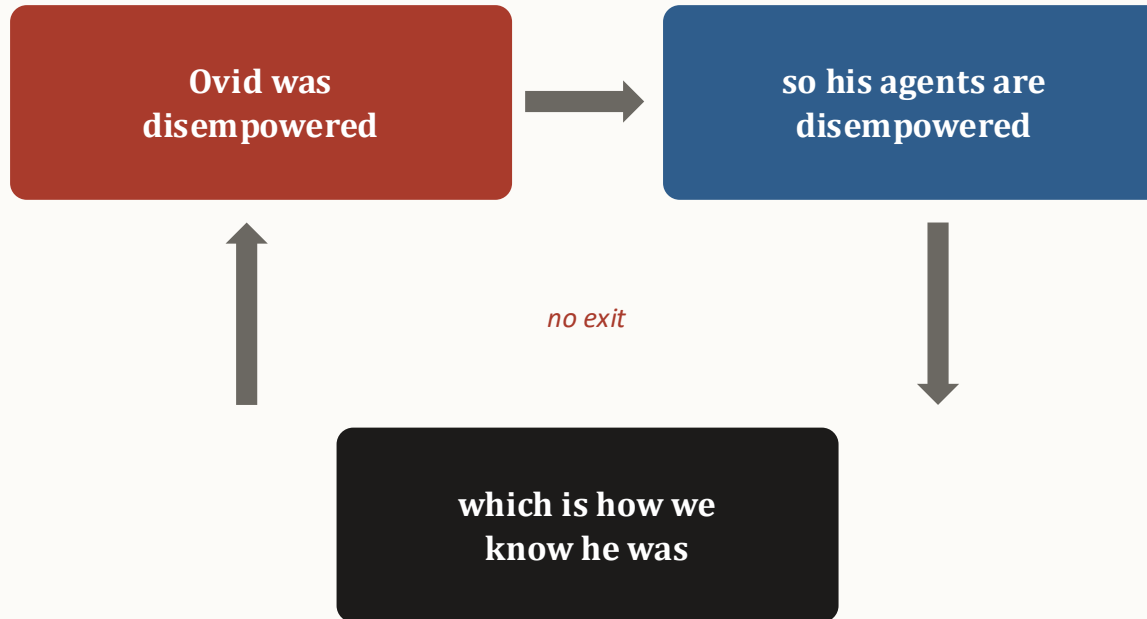
Six problems, in order of severity

Load-bearing problems first, cosmetic problems last

The first three would require rewriting. The last three are quick fixes.



The argument is a closed loop



Nothing could disconfirm it

If the agents had been empowered, that would have been compensation for exile. If they were disempowered, it is reflection. Both outcomes confirm the thesis, which means neither tests it.

And the same loop runs for Sekien

We are told Sekien was empowered by self-exploration. The only evidence offered for that is the prints. The prints are then explained by the empowerment. There is no independent fact about Sekien anywhere in the essay.

The asymmetry is manufactured

Ovid's state is inferred from documented biography; Sekien's is inferred from the artefact. Putting them side by side implies two comparable findings when only one has any external support.

This is the wall

Every section of the essay routes through this claim. It is what makes the comparison a thesis rather than an observation, and it cannot survive being asked what would count against it.

The fix: drop the author-state claim entirely. The structural comparison survives without it.

Three factual claims the argument depends on, and none is safe

“Composed during his exile”

The Metamorphoses was substantially written before the relegation of AD 8, not after it. Ovid says he burned a copy of it as he left. The exile poems are the Tristia and the Epistulae ex Ponto, and they are a different kind of writing.

If the poem predates the banishment, it cannot be a coded response to it.

“Banished for the Ars amatoria”

Ovid gives two causes, a poem and an error, and declines to say what the error was. The link to Julia the Younger is a long-standing scholarly conjecture, not a documented fact, and the essay presents one secondary source’s reconstruction as settled.

A conjecture cannot bear the weight of a thesis without being flagged as one.

“Lost his citizenship”

Relegatio specifically did not entail loss of citizenship or confiscation of property — that is what distinguished it from exilium. The essay’s own emphasis on deprivation overstates a real loss into a technically false one.

Precision here would have cost nothing and strengthened the pathos.

The first one is fatal on its own. Everything in the Ovid half that reads the poem as a disguised complaint about Tomis requires a composition date the poem does not have.

“Essence” is never defined, and does all the work

The claim

That a transformed body is a better indicator of the subject’s essence than the human form was: Daphne’s coldness becomes literal in the laurel; Narcissus’s aloofness and loyalty become the flower beside the pool.

The fix

Define essence, or replace it. The strong version of this argument is narrower: in some tales the new form literalises a trait the human form only asserted, and Ovid uses that device selectively. Then Actaeon is not a counterexample — he is evidence of the selection, and the question becomes when Ovid reaches for it and when he does not.

The Daphne reading is reasonable

Coldness, muteness, intangibility — three specific correspondences, all textually present. As a reading of one tale it works and should be kept.

But the criterion is never stated

What would a transformation that failed to express an essence look like? If no case could fail, the term is not doing analytic work; it is supplying a licence to find a fit.

And the essay’s own example breaks it

Callisto becomes a bear and is nearly killed by her son. Which essence is the bear expressing? The essay raises the case on page two and never returns to it.

Ovid supplies more

Actaeon becomes a stag and is torn apart by his own hounds — an accident of sight, not an expression of character. Io becomes a cow. Arachne, admittedly, becomes a spider, which fits beautifully.

One paragraph does not follow, and the conclusion rests on it

The argument as given (p. 4)

1. Perception is shaped by people's words.
2. Words are human-made, so perceptions are artificial.
3. Therefore all perceptions are artifacts.
4. Therefore the boundary between humans and artifacts disappears.

The fix

The essay does not need the metaphysics. Sekien's plates already show the boundary being blurred as a matter of pictorial technique — a mirror with a face, a bell with a body, a koto with a beard, each still legibly the object it was. That is a claim about images, it is supported by the images, and it is stronger than the philosophical version because it can be checked.

Step 3 to 4 is the break

That a perception is constructed says something about the perception. It says nothing about the ontological status of the perceiver or the thing perceived. My belief about a rock being socially formed does not make me, or the rock, a rock.

"Artifact" shifts meaning mid-argument

In step 3 it means "socially produced." In step 4 it means "a made physical object, like a mirror or a koto." The conclusion only works because one word is doing two jobs.

And the conclusion is reused as settled

The disappearance of the human/artifact boundary reappears in the final section as an established finding. It was never established; it was asserted at the end of a four-step slide.

Two tales, two plates, and one secondary source

1 Four objects for two corpora

Daphne and Narcissus stand for roughly 250 transformations. Ungaikyo and Suzuhiko stand for a whole book. Both pairs are the most famous available, and both sit near the front of their sections. The generalisations are far wider than the sample.

3 The Sekien history is all Foster

Yoshimune, the natural-history policy, the exhibition culture, the taste for the strange — every element of the context is from Pandemonium and Parade, honestly cited. But that means the cultural argument is a summary of one book rather than a reading of a period.

2 The strongest claims are the widest

“Nearly every transformation tale in Metamorphoses is a tragedy, but the persecuted agent always manages either to survive or have his or her goal achieved.” Always is doing a great deal of work on the strength of two cases.

4 And the language constraint is real

The annotations are translated with a professor’s help, which is properly footnoted and entirely creditable. It also caps what the Sekien half can claim, and the essay never says so.

The fix is not more examples

Adding ten more tales would not rescue a generalisation about 250. The fix is to narrow the claim to what four objects can support: not “Ovid’s transformations work like this” but “in these two tales Ovid uses a device that does this, and here is how to spot it elsewhere.” A defensible small claim beats an indefensible large one, and it is almost always more interesting.

A gap that is not there, and the things a second pass catches

The manufactured gap

The essay opens by claiming that scholars have underestimated the motif of transformation in the Metamorphoses. They have not. Transformation is the single most written-about feature of the poem, and the two critics cited are not ignoring it — they are pursuing different questions, which is not the same thing.

The real gap is the one in the next sentence: nobody has put Ovid beside Sekien. That gap is genuine and it needs no straw man to stand up.

Why the last one is a severe problem

A summary at the front followed by the same argument at length is the fossil of a paper that grew out of a shorter one. It is harmless in a draft and expensive in a thesis, because the reader cannot tell which version is authoritative — and the two versions do not quite agree.

Spelling and consistency

Seiken for Sekien three times. Koto-furuhushi in one section, Koto-furunushi in another. Textualized, fasciation, acquisition. A page reference to 72-72.

The Works Cited misses the primary text

The entry is for Gazu hyakki yagyo, the 1776 first book, but the essay is about Tsurezure Bukuro, the 1784 fourth. Page 312 implies a modern collected edition of all four, which should be named as such.

Its own source has better etymology

Tsukumogami is glossed as “gods of tools.” Foster gives the ninety-nine and white-hair derivation, which points at old age — precisely what the essay’s first category needs.

The essay says everything twice

Pages 1 to 5 are a complete compressed version of the argument. Then it restarts at section 1 and says it again at length. The thesis statement arrives on page 5, having already been asserted on page 1.

The best idea in the essay is on page 26, undeveloped

“The motif of transformation doesn’t specify which is the original form and which is the transformation ... A context must be given if we want to know which form is original and which form is later obtained.”

This is a structural claim, and it is original

Transformation as a formal device is symmetrical. A laurel that was a woman and a mirror that became a face are the same figure running in opposite directions. What tells them apart is not the figure but the frame we bring to it.

It dissolves the essay’s own problem

If direction is supplied by context rather than by the motif, then the difference between Ovid and Sekien is a difference of frame — which is a claim about two cultures of reading, and needs no speculation about either author’s mood.

And it arrives two pages from the end

It is stated, illustrated in two sentences, and dropped. Nothing earlier in the essay is revised in its light, and the conclusion returns to the biographical argument as though it had not been made.

The commonest shape of an undergraduate thesis

The real argument is discovered in the process of writing, arrives near the end, and is never promoted — because by then the structure is built and the deadline is close.

A better revision for the essay

1

Promote page 26 to page 1

Open with the symmetry claim: transformation is a directionless figure, and direction is supplied by context. Everything else becomes evidence for it.

2

Cut the biography

Delete Augustus, Tomis and Sekien's inner life. Not because authors do not matter, but because neither case can be established and the argument is better without them.

3

Keep the four objects, narrow the claims

Two tales and two plates are enough to demonstrate a device. They are not enough to characterise a corpus. Say device, not corpus, throughout.

4

Make the pictorial argument the centre

The dotted line versus the solid line; the object still legible inside the humanoid form. This is the essay's best evidence and it currently sits in a subsection.

5

Then ask the question that is left

If direction is a matter of frame, what did each culture bring that made one direction natural? That is a real question, it is unanswered, and it would be worth a second thesis.

Note that four of the five moves are deletions. The revision is shorter than the thesis and says more.

Five questions to ask

What would disconfirm this?

If you cannot name a finding that would have changed your mind, you are not arguing, you are decorating. Write the disconfirming case in the margin before you write the section.

Have I checked the premise, or inherited it?

One unverified date shaped half this essay. Any fact you got from a single secondary source and built on is a fact you should confirm somewhere else before it carries weight.

Is my key term defined?

Essence, boundary, self-projection. Take your three most repeated abstract nouns and write a one-sentence definition of each. If you cannot, they are placeholders.

Does my evidence support the scope of my claim?

Count your objects. Then count the things your thesis sentence is about. If the second number is much larger, shrink the sentence rather than inflating the evidence.

Is the real argument in my last two pages?

Read your conclusion first. If it contains a claim the introduction does not, you found your thesis while writing and have not yet rewritten around it. That is normal, and it is fixable in a day.